Caption Once, Ask Cheaply: What a Question-Blind Caption Index Buys a Video Reader

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Abstract

Captions written once per video window, without the questions, can serve as an index from which a cheaper text reader answers later questions. We ask when such an index lets a reader answer better than it does from the frames, why, and at what cost. The captioner sees exactly the reader's frames, which splits the effect of captions into source, visual budget, captioner and modality effects. On 297 TempCompass questions, with a pre-specified main test, a stronger captioner's captions raise a Claude Haiku reader's accuracy by 0.15 over Haiku's own captions of the same frames, by 0.08 at matched visual tokens, and by 0.06 within one model family at identical input; for an open-weights reader (Qwen2.5-VL-7B) the gain is 0.13. Turning frames into text does not help by itself: Haiku gains at most 0.09 from its own captions, and Claude Sonnet and Qwen lose 0.09 and 0.12. The index pays through the cheaper reader: Haiku on a stronger captioner's index costs 1/23 to 1/26 of Sonnet on frames per question, repays the captioning within 1.2–3.7 questions per video, and is 0–9 points less accurate. On unmanipulated videos, Sonnet's own question-blind index keeps 0.95 of the gain its frames give over the question alone. The losses sit in the benchmark's built stress tests: question-blind captions lose the comparison between two copies of a clip shown at once, and the direction of reversed clips; 61–73% of wrong answers come from captions that do not decide the question.

1 Introduction

Many video question answering systems first caption the video and then reason over the text (Zhang et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025; Zhang et al., 2026). When the captions are written once and reused for every later question, they act as an index: captioning is paid once, and each question costs only a text read. Recent work builds such indexes for long video (Cai et al., 2026; Liang et al., 2026; Chen et al., 2026); in CapMem, a model's own captions beat its frames only on videos over 20 minutes. Two questions remain open. First, when a reader answers better from captions than from frames, the reason is unclear. The captioner may have seen more of the video, spent more visual tokens, or been a stronger model, or text may be easier for the reader than pixels. Second, whether the index pays depends on the full cost per question and on the one-time cost of captioning.

We hold the information fixed. The captioner receives exactly the frames the reader would see. A caption made from these frames cannot contain information about the video that the frames lack (Proposition 1), so an accuracy gain from captions is information that the reader can use more easily, not new information. Arms that change one thing at a time then split the effect of captions into four parts: the source the captioner sees (the video or the reader's frames), the visual tokens it spends, the captioner model, and the modality (a reader's own captions against its own frames). We use two model families: Claude Haiku and Sonnet read, and Haiku, Sonnet and Gemini caption. An open-weights model, Qwen2.5-VL-7B, reads the main arms and captions for itself. The data are 297 multiple-choice questions from TempCompass (Liu et al., 2024), on videos with a median length of 10 s. The main test was specified on a separate development set, before the test questions were run, and each follow-up was logged with a predicted value before it ran.

The captioner matters; the modality does not. With Haiku reading, Gemini's captions of the reader's frames beat Haiku's own by 0.15, and by 0.08 at matched visual tokens; Sonnet's captions of identical input give 0.06. Haiku is no more accurate on its own captions than on the frames they describe (+0.03, CI up to +0.09), and Sonnet is 0.09 less accurate on its own. An open-weights reader (Qwen2.5-VL-7B, greedy decoding) repli-

cates both. On Sonnet's captions both Claude readers score 0.71: a question-blind caption bounds accuracy by what it contains, whatever the reader. The saving comes from a cheaper reader: 1/23 to 1/26 of Sonnet on frames per question, repaid within 1.2–3.7 questions per video, at 0 to 9 points of accuracy. The losses are concentrated. On unmanipulated videos, Sonnet on its own captions is within 0.01 of its frames. When two copies of a clip play at different speeds, question-blind captions do not say which is faster, although the same model, shown the question, often sees it; on reversed clips they describe the forward event or state no direction.

Our contributions are:

1. A decomposition of the effect of captions into source, visual budget, captioner and modality effects, with arms that change one thing each, in two model families (§2.3).

2. A pre-specified test, with replications within one model family at identical input and with an open-weights reader: the captioner effect is positive, and the modality effect at most +0.09 (§4.1–4.2, §4.6).

3. A cost account per question from input, output and thinking tokens, and the break-even number of questions per video, also projected to longer videos (§5).

4. An account of what question-blind captions lose, from minimal pairs, a question-aware control and an audit of wrong answers (§4.3–4.5).

The study is limited to short videos, multiple-choice questions and one benchmark.

2 Setup

2.1 Task and data

We use TempCompass's multiple-choice questions (Liu et al., 2024) on five aspects: action, speed, direction, order and attribute change. A development set of 100 questions set the hypotheses. The confirmatory set samples 60 questions per aspect, one per video, on videos the development set does not use; 297 remain after an amendment (Appendix C). TempCompass builds most of its videos to defeat shortcuts, so we report four video types: plain (137), reversed (74), stacked (41: one clip shown twice, one copy above the other, at two speeds) and two-clip (45). The type nearly determines the aspect. The questions fall into 156 clusters of videos that share a filmed clip. Each video is split into 5 s windows, with one frame per second at 224 px on the long edge (40 Claude image tokens each). The videos are short (median 9.7 s; 58% have one or two windows). We keep the per-window design because it is what scales to long video, and one caption per video does no better (§4.6).

Arm: what the reader sees	Vis. tok./window
Question only: question and options	0
1 frame: the middle frame of each window	40
5 frames: all 5 frames of each window	200
5 frames, 448 px	720
Describe, then answer: 5 frames; one sentence per window, then the answer	200
Self-captions: the reader's own isolated caption of each window's 5 frames	— / 200
Sonnet captions: Sonnet's isolated caption of the same 5 frames	— / 200
Sonnet captions, 448 px: from the 448 px frames	— / 720
Sonnet whole-video captions: one caption of all of a video's frames	— / 200
Sonnet aspect-aware captions: the same, with one bullet naming the kinds of question	— / 200
Gemini frame-clip captions: the same 5 frames, played as a 1 fps clip	— / ≈ 280–330
Gemini frame captions: the same 5 frames, as images	— / ≈ 5,500
Gemini video captions: the video window	— / ≈ 330

Table 1: Arms. Visual tokens per 5 s window, for the reader / for the captioner.

2.2 Arms

Claude Haiku 5.5 and Sonnet 5.5 read (pinned model IDs, effort medium) through `claude -p`, with no tools and a fresh session per call. As an open-weights check, Qwen2.5-VL-7B-Instruct (Bai et al., 2025) (float16, greedy decoding) reads the main arms (§4.6). Haiku, Sonnet, Gemini 3.8 Flash and Qwen caption. A *stronger* captioner means a higher-tier model than the reader (Sonnet or Gemini for Haiku); for Sonnet this is measured, since on the same frames it scores 0.798 against Haiku's 0.613. Every caption is question-blind and sees only its window, and all captioners get one prompt (Appendix A).

2.3 The four effects

Each effect compares two arms that differ in one thing, with Haiku reading (Table 2). *Source*: captions of the video against captions of the reader's frames. *Visual budget*: one captioner's captions of

the same frames at two visual-token counts. *Captioner*: two captioners' captions of the same frames at equal or matched visual tokens. *Modality*: the reader on its own captions of its frames against the reader on those frames. In the Claude chain the first two are zero by design; Gemini's video, frame-clip and frame captions measure them. Along each chain the terms add up to the total.

2.4 Statistics and pre-registration

The main test, P1–P3, was set on the development set and pre-registered before any confirmatory call, and carries 98.33% CIs (Bonferroni over three). Every other comparison is exploratory: it was written down with a predicted value and committed before its first call, its analysis was run once, and it carries a 95% CI. Appendix B lists every term with its prediction. CIs are paired bootstrap over questions; "cl." marks a CI from resampling the 156 clip clusters instead, and the two agree throughout. The repository's full history, which holds each prediction in a commit dated before its run, is archived by Software Heritage (identifier withheld for review). Commit dates are set by the author; the open-reader entry was also pushed publicly before its run.

3 Theory

Proposition 1 (garbling). A caption made from the reader's own frames is a garbling of them, so for an unbounded reader it cannot add information about the video. A bounded reader can still get more *usable* information (Xu et al., 2020) from a good caption than from the pixels, and that is what the captioner effect measures. The total effect of captions is then the sum of the source, captioner and modality effects, plus a visual-budget term when the visual tokens differ.

Proposition 2 (break-even). An index τ that costs $C(\tau)$ per video and c_τ per question pays for itself, against frames at c_f per question, after

$$Q_{\mathrm{BE}} = \frac{C(\tau)}{c_f - c_\tau}$$

questions per video, the break-even quantity. With a reader downgrade, c_τ is the cheaper reader's cost. If each of W windows is captioned in its own call at cost k, and costs the reader s_f as frames and s_τ as text, then $Q_{\mathrm{BE}} \to k/(s_f - s_\tau)$ as W grows: on long videos the per-window prices set the break-even, not the fixed prompt.

Proposition 3 (omission). A question-aware description recovers what a question-blind caption omits, so a loss that disappears when the question is shown is an omission, not a limit of text.

Retention, (captions − question only) / (frames − question only), is the share of the frames' gain over the question alone that an index keeps.

4 Results

All results are on the 297 confirmatory questions, and no question is missing from any arm. Differences are in accuracy, so +0.064 is 6.4 points.

Table 3 lists the main arms (the variants are in Table 10). Two rows anchor the rest. With the question and options alone, both readers score 0.41 (Haiku 0.411, Sonnet 0.414; difference +0.003 [−0.061, +0.064]), well above chance (≈ 0.30): the wording carries a strong prior, and the two readers share it. Given five frames per window, Sonnet scores 0.185 more than Haiku (0.798 vs. 0.613). Since the floor is shared, that whole gap comes from reading the input. Every index Haiku reads lands between these two points (0.643–0.791), and every index Sonnet reads lands below its frames (0.710–0.791).

4.1 Who writes the caption matters

Table 2 splits the caption effect into source, visual budget, captioner and modality effects. The pre-registered test is P3. With Haiku as the reader, Gemini's captions of exactly the reader's frames beat Haiku's own captions of them by +0.148 [+0.088, +0.209], 2.5× the predicted +0.06. The gain is positive in every aspect (+0.10 to +0.20) and in every video type (Appendix D).

P3 compares two captioners that spent different visual tokens on the same pixels. Gemini's image path encodes each 224 px frame at ≈ 1,100 tokens, ≈ 5,500 per window, against Haiku's 200. Captioning the same frames as a 1 fps clip through Gemini's video path (≈ 280–330 tokens per window, equal to the video arm's in 693 of 761 windows) splits P3 into two halves: a captioner effect at about matched visual tokens, +0.081 [+0.030, +0.131], cl. [+0.035, +0.125]; and a visual budget effect, +0.067 [+0.030, +0.108].

The source effect is near zero (+0.013 [−0.030, +0.061]): with captioner and visual tokens fixed, captions of the original video are no more useful than captions of the reader's 224 px frames. Gemini's video path reduces each frame to ≈ 66 tokens, so the source's resolution mostly does not reach the captioner. All four predictions for this split were

Effect	Arms compared	Claude chain	Gemini chain
Source	video captions − frame-clip captions	0 by design	+0.013 [−0.030, +0.061]
Visual budget	frame captions − frame-clip captions	0 by design (+0.003 at 448 px)	+0.067 [+0.030, +0.108]
Captioner	other captioner − self-captions, same pixels	+0.064 [+0.017, +0.111]	+0.081 [+0.030, +0.131]
Modality	self-captions − 5 frames	+0.030 [−0.034, +0.094] (P2)	(same)
Total	other captioner − 5 frames	+0.094 [+0.044, +0.148]	P3 + P2; frame captions: +0.178

Table 2: The four effects, with Haiku reading. Accuracy differences on 297 questions, 95% paired bootstrap CIs (P2 and P3: 98.33%).

Reader, input	Acc.	In tok.	$/q	Index
H, question only	0.411	1,025	1.09	—
H, 5 frames	0.613	1,520	2.04	—
H, self-captions	0.643	1,283	1.89	0.58
H, Sonnet capt.	0.707	1,280	1.81	9.10
H, Gem. frame-clip	0.724	1,232	1.67	7.60
H, Gem. frame	0.791	1,229	1.67	14.61
H, Gem. video	0.737	1,236	1.68	7.26
S, question only	0.414	1,027	21.82	—
S, 5 frames	0.798	1,522	41.12	—
S, Sonnet capt.	0.710	1,282	30.89	9.10
S, Gem. video	0.791	1,238	28.68	7.26
Q, question only	0.397	121	—	—
Q, 5 frames	0.657	529	—	—
Q, Qwen capt.	0.535	268	—	—
Q, Sonnet capt.	0.660	295	—	9.10
Q, Gem. video	0.697	264	—	7.26

Table 3: Accuracy and list-price cost per question (297 questions; H = Haiku, S = Sonnet, Q = Qwen reading). Qwen runs on a free GPU, so it has no price; its input tokens have no CLI system prompt. Input tokens are the median per question and include the fixed reader prompt ($\approx$ 1,025 tokens). $/q is list-price dollars per question $\times 10^4$, including output and thinking tokens. Index is the one-time captioning cost in dollars per video $\times 10^3$, averaged over videos (§5). The variant arms are in Table 10.

within 0.02 of the results.

Within one model family, the match is exact. Sonnet captions the same five JPEGs per window, with the same prompt and effort as Haiku's self-captions. Every Claude model counts image tokens by the same rule, and Sonnet's caption calls took exactly 2 more input tokens than Haiku's in every window (876). Only the captioning model differs. Haiku reads Sonnet's captions more accurately than its own: **+0.064 [+0.017, +0.111]**, cl. [+0.011, +0.119]. The predicted +0.09 lies inside the CI. At about equal visual tokens, the two families' captioners are equally useful to Haiku (Sonnet − Gemini frame-clip captions, −0.017 [−0.071, +0.037]). On minimal pairs (§4.3), where a guess cannot score, the captioner effect is +0.104 [+0.017, +0.190] in pair accuracy. With an open-weights reader the effect is larger: Qwen reads Sonnet's captions of the same frames +0.125 [+0.074, +0.175], cl. [+0.070, +0.182], more accurately than its own (§4.6).

Unlike Gemini's, Claude's captioner gains nothing from a larger visual budget in the range we tested: Sonnet's captions of 448 px frames, at 3.6× the visual tokens, are no more useful to Haiku, +0.003 [−0.037, +0.047] (Appendix E).

4.2 Text itself is not easier for the reader

The modality effect asks whether a reader does better on its own words than on the pixels they came from. For Haiku this is the pre-registered P2: self-captions − 5 frames = +0.030 [−0.034, +0.094]. Both the prediction (−0.08) and any gain above +0.09 lie outside the CI; IsoBench (Fu et al., 2024), by contrast, finds 15–29 points for exact text renderings of images. For Sonnet, its own captions cost accuracy: −0.088 [−0.135, −0.044], cl. [−0.140, −0.036], and −0.067 [−0.114, −0.024] when it captions the 448 px frames. For Qwen, its own captions cost −0.121 [−0.172, −0.071], cl. [−0.170, −0.074]; Qwen reads frames better than Haiku (0.657 vs. 0.613), and its captions are the least useful in the study (§4.6). So the modality effect is near 0 for the reader that reads frames worst (Haiku) and negative for the two that read them better.

Figure 1 shows why. From Haiku to Sonnet, accuracy on frames rises from 0.613 to 0.798, while accuracy on Sonnet's captions stays flat (0.707 → 0.710; paired difference −0.003 [−0.047, +0.040]). On these captions, a reader that costs 17× less per question loses nothing measurable. We read this as a cap: a question-blind caption bounds any reader's accuracy by what the caption holds. Haiku on frames is below the cap of Sonnet's captions and gains from them; Sonnet is above it and loses. Qwen reaches the cap only at the edge (0.660, −0.047 [−0.094, +0.000] below Haiku), and falls short on two-clip and stacked videos. The

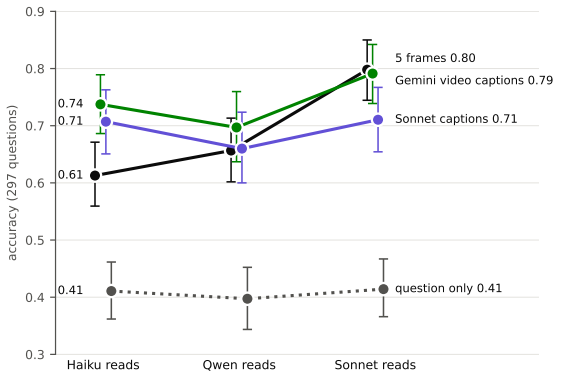


Figure 1: Accuracy by reader, in order of accuracy on frames, for the question alone, 5 frames, and the two indexes every reader read. 95% CIs over clip clusters. The frames line crosses both index lines.

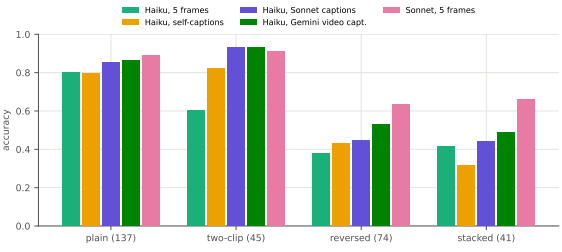


Figure 2: Accuracy by video type for five arms (297 questions; n per type in brackets).

cap depends on the index. Sonnet reads Gemini's video captions better than its own (0.791 vs. 0.710, +0.081 [+0.034, +0.128]), and keeps 0.98, cl. [0.85, 1.13], of its frames' gain over the question alone on them, against 0.77, cl. [0.64, 0.90], on its own captions (retention, §3). This pattern was not predicted, and it is exploratory. Haiku's advantage on captions does not come from starving the frames: captions still beat 448 px frames at 1.76× the input tokens (Appendix E).

4.3 Where captions lose: video types and minimal pairs

Built videos (reversed, stacked, two-clip) are 54% of the confirmatory set, and every stacked question is about speed and every two-clip question about order, so we report by type (Figure 2). On plain videos, the five arms lie within 0.09 of each other (0.80–0.89). They separate on the built videos.

Accuracy on one video cannot tell a representation that lost the fact from a reader that guessed. Minimal pairs can. Each of 193 confirmatory questions is asked again, with the same wording and option order, on a sibling video built from the same

Arm	All	Rev. (107)	Stack. (41)	2-clip (45)	Same ans.
H, 5 frames	0.233	0.28	0.17	0.18	0.54
H, self-captions	0.326	0.33	0.10	0.53	0.42
H, Sonnet capt.	0.430	0.38	0.17	0.78	0.43
H, Gem. video	0.482	0.47	0.20	0.78	0.37
S, 5 frames	0.606	0.56	0.51	0.80	0.28
S, Sonnet capt.	0.430	0.40	0.10	0.80	0.39

Table 4: Minimal pairs: pair accuracy by group, and the share of pairs with the same answer on both videos. Chance pair accuracy is 0.093.

filmed clip whose correct option differs: the plain and the reversed version of a clip (107 pairs); another stacked version at other speeds (41); another arrangement of the same two clips (45). An arm that does not receive the fact gives the same answer on both videos, and gets at most one of them right. Table 4 reports pair accuracy, the share of pairs answered correctly on both sides (chance 0.093), and the same-answer rate.

Two-clip: captions help a weak reader. From frames, Haiku must keep about ten small frames from two clips apart, and on two-clip pairs it is near chance (0.18). Its own captions raise pair accuracy to 0.53, a modality effect of +0.36 [+0.16, +0.56] (+0.22 [+0.10, +0.35] cl. in accuracy), and Sonnet's captions raise its accuracy over its frames by +0.33, cl. [+0.20, +0.48]. Both were predicted. Describing each window before answering, in the same call, gains only +0.09 [−0.06, +0.24] here, which leans toward the separate caption call per window as the cause, without showing it.

Stacked: question-blind captions drop the comparison. Sonnet on frames answers 0.51 of stacked pairs correctly on both sides. Every caption arm scores 0.10–0.20, near pair chance, including Sonnet on its own captions (0.10; −0.41 [−0.62, −0.23] against its frames). The captions do not say how the copies differ: they give the same answer on both videos of a pair more often than Sonnet on frames (Haiku on Sonnet captions +0.32 [+0.07, +0.55]). For a man jumping rope in two copies (answer: the one above is faster), Gemini writes "An athletic man … jumps rope in a split-screen video". Sonnet sees the difference when it looks with the question in view, and loses it when it writes without the question. The loss lies in what a question-blind captioner writes, not in what it can see.

Reversed: captions narrate forward, or do not commit. The question alone points to the forward event: both readers score below chance on reversed videos (Haiku 0.16, Sonnet 0.18). Sonnet on frames recovers part of the reversal (0.64), but its question-blind captions keep little of it: Sonnet on its own captions trails its frames by −0.18, cl. [−0.30, −0.05], and Haiku on them trails Sonnet on frames by −0.19, cl. [−0.32, −0.07]. Sonnet's captions report reversals no more often than Haiku's (+0.01 [−0.08, +0.10]; a gain was predicted), and Gemini's do so a little more (+0.14 [+0.04, +0.24]). A reader that misses the reversal falls back to the prior: 0.59 (frames) and 0.65 (own captions) of Sonnet's wrong answers on reversed videos equal its question-only answer, against 0.43 if errors were uniform. For a pile of salt played backwards (answer: shrinking), all five of Gemini's video captions describe salt pouring onto the pile.

4.4 Why caption arms fail: an audit

For every caption set and question that a reader got wrong in one of seven reader arms (442 items; two readers share some caption sets), a judge (Sonnet) saw the captions, question, options and correct answer, and labelled the captions as stating the correct option (a reader error), a wrong option (a misstatement), or neither (an omission), quoting the caption as evidence (Appendix A; Table 5).

Omission dominates: 0.61–0.73 of every arm's wrong answers come from captions that do not decide the question. Misstatements are 0.15–0.28, and reader errors only 0.05–0.17, below the predicted 0.15–0.25. A fact missing from the index cannot be read from it by any reader, which fits the cap of §4.2. By video type, the stacked prediction held: in every arm, 0.93–1.00 of stacked failures are omissions (predicted $\geq$ 0.70). The reversed prediction failed. Misstatement, that is forward narration, is 0.28–0.45 of reversed failures, below the predicted $\geq$ 0.50, and omission is 0.45–0.62. On reversed videos, captions narrate the forward event or do not commit to a direction.

The judge also wrote one of the caption sets it labels. One author's 40 labels, stratified by the judge's label and blind to it, agree at $\kappa = 0.81$ [0.64, 0.96] (threshold 0.6, set in advance); all 5 disagreements are items the author left "silent", so if anything Table 5 undercounts omission. The audit by video type is in Appendix E.

Reader arm	Reader err.	Misstat.	Omission	n
H, self-captions	0.08	0.28	0.63	106
H, Sonnet capt.	0.13	0.26	0.61	87
H, Gem. frame-clip	0.17	0.15	0.68	82
H, Gem. frame	0.10	0.18	0.73	62
H, Gem. video	0.10	0.21	0.69	78
S, Gem. video	0.05	0.24	0.71	62
S, Sonnet capt.	0.08	0.26	0.66	86

Table 5: Caption audit: share of each reader arm's wrong answers by the judge's label of the captions. Reader error = the captions state the correct option; misstatement = a wrong option; omission = neither. n = wrong answers.

4.5 From question-blind to question-aware

Two arms move the captioner toward the question. Neither changes the confirmatory captioner prompt.

Describe, then answer. Haiku sees the 5 frames per window and the question, writes one sentence per window, and then answers, all in one call. It scores 0.684, +0.071 over the frames arm, cl. [+0.029, +0.114] (predicted +0.03). The gain is on reversed and stacked videos (+0.12 each). On stacked videos, this question-aware description beats the question-blind self-captions by **+0.22 [+0.09, +0.37]**. So the stacked loss is an omission caused by not seeing the question, not a limit of text (Proposition 3). This arm is not an index: it reads the frames at every question, and it costs 2× the frames arm per question ($0.000415 vs. $0.000204), mostly in thinking tokens.

Telling the captioner the kinds of question. Between question-blind and question-aware sits a task-aware index. Sonnet's whole-video captions (§4.6) get one added prompt bullet that names the five kinds of question to come, but not how the benchmark builds its videos. Over the whole-video captions, Sonnet reading them gains +0.040 [+0.003, +0.081], cl. [+0.000, +0.081], and Haiku +0.027 [−0.013, +0.067]; both match the predicted +0.03. This halves Sonnet's gap to its own frames (−0.077 → −0.037 [−0.081, +0.007]), but not on stacked videos, where Sonnet on frames stays 0.27 ahead, and mentions of reversal do not rise. The captions are also 15% longer, so part of the gain may be more words rather than the right ones. Knowing the task buys a little; the stacked comparison needs the question itself.

4.6 Robustness checks and nulls

An open-weights reader. Qwen2.5-VL-7B-Instruct, with greedy decoding and the same prompts, reads eight arms and captions every window from exactly the 5 frames. Unparsed answers count as wrong (Appendix E). Qwen reads frames well (0.657, above Haiku's 0.613), but its own captions are the weakest in the study, even for itself (Haiku's are +0.067 [+0.020, +0.114] better). Besides the captioner and modality effects (§4.1–4.2; the modality cost of −0.121 was predicted as −0.01), Gemini's video captions add only +0.040 [−0.010, +0.091] over Qwen's frames (predicted +0.12).

Other checks (Appendix E). One Sonnet caption per video instead of one per window does no better (+0.013 with Haiku reading, +0.010 with Sonnet; predicted ≈ 0), at half the index cost. Re-captioning identical input changes 10–17% of answers, so comparisons between caption arms, and by type, are noisy. The pre-registered aspect contrast (P1) did not pass: −0.101 [−0.231, +0.028] for Sonnet, half the predicted −0.20.

5 Cost and break-even

Accounting. We price every call at list price: Claude Haiku 5.5 at $0.10 / $0.50 and Sonnet 5.5 at $2 / $10 per million input / output tokens, with thinking billed as output (this equals the CLI's reported cost on every call), and Gemini captioning at $0.50 / $3.00. A reader's cost per question, c, is the mean over the 297 questions, and an index's cost per video, $C(\tau)$, is the cost of captioning all its windows once. Q_{BE} follows Proposition 2; its CIs resample questions, and so videos, since each video has one question.

For one reader, the index saves little. Against 5 frames, Gemini video captions save 18% per question for Haiku and 30% for Sonnet. The fixed reader prompt (≈ 1,025 tokens) dominates the input: captions cut the video-content tokens to 43% of the frames', but the input tokens only to 81%. So for one reader the index repays slowly: Sonnet on Gemini video captions after $Q_{\mathrm{BE}} = 5.8$ [5.2, 6.5], at equal accuracy (−0.007 [−0.054, +0.040]), and Haiku on them only after 202 [156, 279], though 0.125 more accurate than on its frames.

The reader downgrade is what pays. Per question, Haiku on any index written by a stronger captioner costs 1/23 to 1/26 of Sonnet on frames (Table 3), and the index repays its captioning within 1.2–3.7 questions per video (Table 11 in Appendix E). At 10 questions per video (Figure 3, middle), every index Haiku reads costs less than half of Sonnet on frames, captioning included. The accuracy cost of the downgrade depends on the index. Gemini frame captions let Haiku match Sonnet on frames (−0.007 [−0.057, +0.044]), but they are the most expensive index ($0.0146 per video), because Gemini's image path spends ≈ 5,500 visual tokens per window. In the Claude chain, where Sonnet captions once and Haiku answers, the cost is −0.091 [−0.145, −0.040] at $Q_{\mathrm{BE}} = 2.3$; aspect-aware captions bring it to −0.051 [−0.104, +0.000] at $Q_{\mathrm{BE}} = 1.3$.

Longer videos. Projected by Proposition 2 to videos whose every window is read (Appendix E), captions save more per question as videos grow, but Q_{BE} does not fall, because captioning grows with every window too: for the reader downgrade it rises from 1.8–3.7 to 4.5–8.9 at one minute.

6 Related work

Caption, then reason. Many video QA systems caption first and reason over the text (Zhang et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025; Zhang et al., 2026; Wang et al., 2024); LLoVi already finds that the captioner matters. Caption indexes and memories reuse the captions across questions (Cai et al., 2026; Liang et al., 2026; Chen et al., 2026; Goulas et al., 2025). Caption utility is also judged by QA rather than by similarity (Yang et al., 2026; Wang et al., 2026b; han Li et al., 2026), and CapRL (Xing et al., 2025) trains a captioner on it. Prism (Qiao et al., 2024) and MetaCaptioner (Lei et al., 2025) vary the captioner in front of a fixed reader. CapMem (Liang et al., 2026) is closest: on long egocentric video, Qwen readers read six Qwen captioners' captions of the same frames, and their own, but it does not split source from visual budget, cross families or price a cheaper reader. Its stronger reader gains on fixed captions; our cap is where that gain ends.

Text or pixels. IsoBench (Fu et al., 2024) finds 15–29 points for exact text renderings of images, and TokenSwap (Hua et al., 2026) studies the same contrast. For a model reading its own description, the sign varies: own captions give a weak 7B model +22 to +29 points on synthetic image tasks (Weng et al., 2025), while appending the model's own caption costs about 10 points on HallusionBench

Type (n)	Question only	Frames	Own captions	Perception shortfall	Index loss	Retention
plain (137)	0.61	0.89	0.88	0.11 [0.06, 0.16]	+0.01 [−0.03, +0.06]	0.95 [0.79, 1.12]
two-clip (45)	0.29	0.91	0.91	0.09 [0.02, 0.17]	+0.00 [−0.07, +0.06]	1.00 [0.91, 1.12]
reversed (74)	0.18	0.64	0.46	0.36 [0.25, 0.48]	**+0.18** [+0.05, +0.30]	0.62 [0.35, 0.88]
stacked (41)	0.32	0.66	0.39	0.34 [0.17, 0.51]	**+0.27** [+0.09, +0.47]	0.21 [−0.27, 0.67]
all (297)	0.41	0.80	0.71	0.20 [0.15, 0.26]	+0.09 [+0.04, +0.14]	0.77 [0.64, 0.90]

Table 6: Where Sonnet's headroom goes, by video type (Sonnet as captioner and reader; 95% CIs over clip clusters).

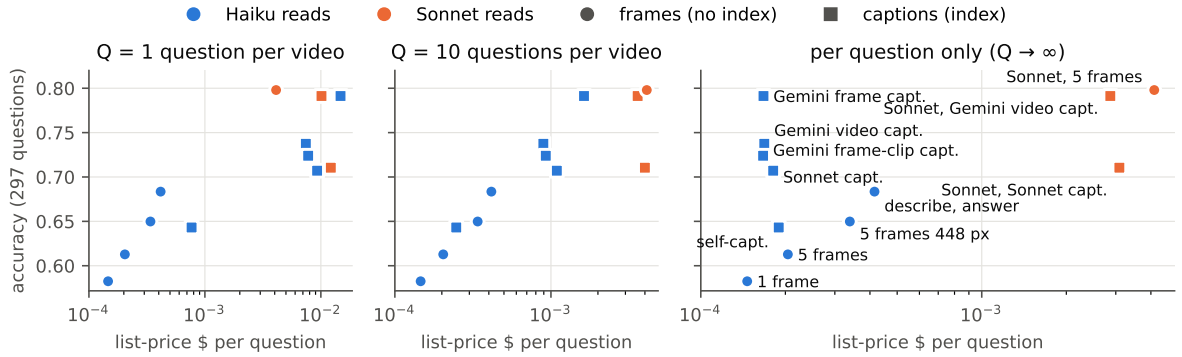


Figure 3: Accuracy against list-price $ per question (log scale), one point per arm, with the index cost spread over Q = 1, 10 and infinitely many questions per video. Circles are frame arms, and squares are index arms. Question only (0.41 for both readers) is below the axis; the 448 px caption, whole-video and aspect-aware variants are in Table 10 only.

(Li and Zhang, 2026), and a one-call "state first" prompt does not help on charts (Wang et al., 2026a). Our modality effect is at most +0.09 for Haiku and negative for Sonnet and Qwen, which fits a sign set by where the reader stands relative to what the caption holds, and CapMem's sign on videos under 20 minutes.

Temporal video and cost. Minimal pairs follow TempCompass's conflicting videos (Liu et al., 2024), MotionBlind (Bhatia et al., 2026) and TimeBlind (Li et al., 2026); we apply them to representations rather than to models. Video models often fail direction, speed and reversal from pixels too (Lee et al., 2026; Xue et al., 2025; Rahman, 2026; Li et al., 2024), which fits P1's null. We found no paper that solves for break-even with a reader downgrade; on cost see Dwivedi et al. (2026); Zhao et al. (2026); Yammine et al. (2026); Dong et al. (2026); Guan et al. (2026); Kapoor et al. (2024); Chen et al. (2023).

7 Discussion

What the benchmark tests when the captioner is also misled. A low score might only mean that TempCompass's built videos fooled the captioner, but the arms separate the two causes: the same model also reads the same pixels with the question in view. Table 6 (descriptive) splits Sonnet's headroom into a perception shortfall, 1 − frames, and an index loss, frames − own captions (seen when asked, not written down blind). On plain and two-clip videos the index loss is ≈ 0, and the index keeps 0.95–1.00 of the frames' gain. On reversed videos Sonnet is misled even with the question in view (shortfall 0.36), and writing blind loses another 0.18; on stacked videos it sees the comparison when asked (0.66), but its blind captions keep little of it (retention 0.21, wide CI). For Haiku the index loss is negative (−0.09; Appendix E). **Why the baselines are needed.** The same captions help Haiku and cost Sonnet (retention 1.47, 0.77): without self-caption, frames and question-only arms, a "caption effect" mixes captioner, modality and prior.

Future work. Three extensions follow.

- **Contamination.** A test set built from videos released after the readers' training data, with answers made by editing the videos (reversal, order, splicing), would leave nothing to remember.
- **Long gaps.** Masking a span and asking which candidate fills it, with distractors from the same video, recasts reconstruction as a ques-

tion with a metric that both modalities share. Over a 1 s gap, frame continuity wins (Appendix E). Over long gaps we expect the opposite. One can guess the missing twenty minutes of a wedding (vows, rings, the pronouncement) from what usually happens, but not what they looked like.

- **Long videos.** The same experiment on long videos would test where captioning everything stops paying, together with readers that retrieve a few windows.

8 Conclusion

Given exactly the reader's frames, a stronger captioner's question-blind captions make Claude Haiku and an open 7B reader more accurate, while no reader gains more than 0.09 from its own captions. The index pays through the cheaper reader. It loses what a captioner does not write without the question: comparisons between two copies of a clip, and reversals.

Limitations

Scope. We test one benchmark, short clips (median 9.7 s) and multiple-choice questions. 54% of the confirmatory videos are manipulated (reversed, stacked, two-clip), so overall accuracies mix natural video with stress tests; plain videos are reported separately (Table 6). The costs for longer videos (§5) are projections from short clips, for a reader that reads every window. All captions follow one generic, question-blind prompt that does not mention the benchmark's manipulations; captions written for retrieval or question answering may keep more.

Contamination. TempCompass (March 2024) predates every reader's training data (June 2026 for the Claude models), so the readers may have seen its questions. The question alone scores 0.40–0.41, 0.11 above chance, but this comes from a third of the questions. For 197 of the 297 confirmatory questions, TempCompass itself asks the same question, with the same options, of another video with another answer, so a remembered answer cannot fit both. On these 197 the question alone is at chance (Haiku +0.02, Sonnet −0.01), and the headline effects keep their signs: captioner +0.08 [+0.02, +0.14], cap +0.02 [−0.04, +0.07], Haiku on Sonnet's captions vs. Sonnet on frames −0.11 [−0.18, −0.04]. None is smaller there than on the other 100. On minimal-pair accuracy, which a text-only answer cannot earn, they hold too (Table 4; the cap is 0.00 [−0.07, +0.06]). We did not extend the study to EgoSchema (Mangalam et al., 2023), because in a development run Sonnet scored 0.72 from the question alone (chance 0.20; 39 questions).

Readers. The closed readers run through a CLI, so its system prompt is part of every input and temperature is not controlled. Thinking is decided per call by the model (effort medium), so it is observed, not controlled. Mitigations are pinned model IDs, isolation checked on every call, released outputs, and an open-weights reader with greedy decoding that replicates the captioner and modality results (§4.6); it is one 7B model, with its own default system prompt. In the main chain Claude reads Claude's captions; the Gemini chain and the Qwen reader check this. Haiku's accuracy on frames dropped from the development to the confirmatory set (0.70 to 0.61); about half of the drop is the different mix of video types.

Inference. Questions share filmed clips, so we also report CIs over clip clusters. Most claims beyond the pre-registered test are exploratory: each follow-up was predicted in writing before it ran, but the cap, the thinking pattern and the analysis by video type of the first two runs were not. The audit's judge (Sonnet) also wrote one of the caption sets it judges; 40 blind hand labels check it (κ = 0.81).

Question-blind captions drop what the question needs and the captioner did not write (stacked comparisons, reversals). Since the same model recovers the stacked comparison when it describes the frames with the question in view (§4.5), this is a limit of question-blind indexes, not only of our captioners.

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A Prompts

All prompts are given exactly as sent. Text in braces is filled in per call.

Caption prompt. Every captioner gets the same prompt. For frames (Haiku, Sonnet, and Gemini's frame and frame-clip captions), the first sentence is:

```
The attached images are {n} frames from a {d}-second video
      clip, taken one second apart and shown in time order.
      Describe what happens in the clip, in one or two
      sentences of at most 45 words in total.
```

For Gemini's video captions, it is "Describe what happens in the attached 5-second video clip, in one or two sentences of at most 45 words in total." The rest is the same for all:

```
* Start with what happens: what the people, animals or
      machines do, or, if nothing in the clip acts, how the
      scene or the camera view changes.
* Then add the details that set this moment apart: the key
      objects and any on-screen text, but do not transcribe
      subtitles, clocks, timestamps, dates or numbering (
      such as day, part or step numbers), and leave out
      watermarks and channel logos.
* Describe the setting in a few words at most.
* Mention camera movement only when the camera clearly moves.

* Describe what is seen, not what is heard.
* Include enough details so someone who hasn't seen the
      video could understand what's happening.
* If a description cannot be generated, write "ERROR".
```

The whole-video captions (§4.6) get all of a video's frames in one call, and the length clause scales with the number of windows (for two windows: "in at most 4 sentences of at most 90 words in total"). The aspect-aware captions (§4.5) add one bullet before the last:

```
* The description will be used later to answer questions
      about the actions, the speed of the movements, the
      direction of the movements, the order of the events,
      and changes in the attributes of things (such as size,
       colour, shape or state). State these whenever the
      frames show them.
```

Reader prompt.

```
Answer a multiple-choice question about a video clip that is
      {duration} seconds long. There is no sound.

{modality}

{evidence}

Question: {stem}
{options}

Answer with JSON only, in this format: {"answer": "<letter
      >"}, with one of the letters {letters}.
```

The evidence is the frames or the captions, each window labelled with its time span ("0-5 s:"). The modality sentence is, for frames:

```
The video was split into windows of 5 seconds (the last one
      may be shorter). Each window is shown as its frames
      taken one second apart, in time order.
```

for captions:

```
The video was split into windows of 5 seconds (the last one
      may be shorter). Each window is given as a short
      description of what can be seen in it, in time order.
      Each description was written by an AI model that
      watched only that one window, without sound, and knew
      nothing about the rest of the video.
```

for whole-video captions:

```
The video is given as a single description of what can be
      seen in it. The description was written by an AI model
       that watched the whole video, without sound.
```

for one frame per window, "… Each window is shown as one frame from its middle, in time order."; and for the question only, "You cannot see

the video. Give your best guess from the question and options alone."

Describe, then answer. The reader prompt with frames, with the last paragraph replaced by:

```
First describe each window in one sentence, in time order:
      what can be seen in it and what happens. Then answer.
      Answer with JSON only, in this format: {"windows": ["<
      window 1>", "<window 2>", ...], "answer": "<letter>"},
       with one description per window and one of the
      letters {letters}.
```

Audit judge (§4.4).

```
You are checking whether written descriptions of a video
      contain the answer to a question about it.

The video is {duration} seconds long, without sound. It was
      split into windows of 5 seconds (the last one may be
      shorter). An AI model wrote one description per window,
       seeing only that one window and not the question:

{captions}

Question: {stem}
{options}

The correct answer is {answer}. {answer_text}

Judge the descriptions only, not what you think the video
      shows. Choose one label:
- "correct": the descriptions state the correct answer, or
      imply it clearly enough that a careful reader would
      choose it.
- "wrong": the descriptions state, or clearly imply, a
      different option.
- "silent": the descriptions do not decide between the
      options: the fact needed is missing or too vague.

Answer with JSON only, in this format: {"label": "<correct|
      wrong|silent>", "evidence": "<a short quote from the
      descriptions, or an empty string>"}
```

B Development phase and predictions

Development phase. The hypotheses came from 100 development questions (20 per aspect, one per video, on videos the confirmatory set does not use), read by Haiku (question only, Gemini video captions, 1 and 5 frames per window) and Sonnet (Gemini video captions and 5 frames), and on 50 of them by Haiku with its own captions. On them, Haiku on Gemini captions tied Haiku on 5 frames (+0.01 [−0.07, +0.09]); Sonnet lost on the captions (−0.07 [−0.15, 0.00]), mostly on direction and speed; and Haiku's own captions were below its frames (−0.10 [−0.22, +0.02]) and below Gemini's captions (−0.08 [−0.18, 0.00]). These gave P1 (captions lose direction and speed: the grouping direction, speed against the other three aspects was fixed before any confirmatory call), P2 (no modality advantage, predicted −0.08) and P3 (the captioner adds usable information, +0.06). The development predictions were too pessimistic about captions: S1, S3, S5 and S6 all came out higher than predicted (Table 7). Part of the shift is the mix of video types: built videos are 40% of the development set and 54% of the confirmatory set, and weighting the confirmatory accuracies by the development mix accounts for about half of Haiku's drop on frames (0.70 → 0.61).

Predictions against results. Every exploratory term was written down with a predicted value and committed before its first call. Table 7 lists every predicted term. Of the 50 accuracy differences in it, the prediction lies inside the result's CI for 39, and for 37 of the 41 after C1. Of the 44 non-zero predictions, 42 have the sign of the result; the two exceptions are P2 and S2, both set from the 50 development questions. The median absolute difference between prediction and estimate is 0.021. The misses after C1 are C4e (Sonnet's pair-accuracy loss on its own captions, larger than predicted) and three open-reader terms (C12a, d, f), whose predictions treated Qwen as a weaker Haiku; it reads frames better than Haiku and writes less useful captions (§4.6).

C Amendments, deviations and term mapping

Terms. The pre-registration called the modality effect the *format* effect, and the source effect *coverage*; they were renamed before any later entry, and the pre-registered entries keep their words. C1's coverage term (S2: Gemini video − frame captions) mixes the source with a 17× difference in visual tokens, so the paper's source effect is C2c, at about matched tokens.

Amendments, each made before the calls it affects.

- **Sampling (C1).** The first sampling rule (aspects filled rarest first) reached only 59 action and 59 direction questions and wrote no file; a preference for videos with a single aspect was added, and the sample was drawn once.
- **Gemini image cost (C1).** Gemini encodes each 224 px image at ≈ 1,085 tokens at its default media resolution, not the assumed ≈ 66, so a frame-caption call cost about 3× the planned amount; the spend cap was raised and the resolution kept, so the captioner settings stayed as tested.
- **Exclusions (C1).** Gemini returned no caption for 4 of 1,544 windows (0.26%, below the

Term	Pred.	Result [95% CI]
C1, pre-registered; P1–P3 with 98.33% CIs		
P1 aspect contrast, S reads	−0.20	−0.101 [−0.231, +0.028]
P2 modality, H	−0.08	+0.030 [−0.034, +0.094]
P3 H: Gem. frame − self capt.	+0.06	+0.148 [+0.088, +0.209]
S1 S: Gem. video capt. − frames	−0.07	−0.007 [−0.054, +0.040]
S2 H: Gem. video − frame capt.	+0.02	−0.054 [−0.098, −0.013]
S3 H: Gem. video capt. − frames	0.00	+0.125 [+0.071, +0.178]
S4 aspect contrast, H reads	−0.12	−0.055 [−0.172, +0.060]
S5 H: Gem. video capt. − 1 frame	+0.05	+0.155 [+0.098, +0.212]
S6 H on Gem. video − S on frames	−0.13	−0.061 [−0.111, −0.010]
C2, frame-clip captions (H reads)		
C2a frame-clip − self capt.	+0.10	+0.081 [+0.030, +0.131]
C2b frame − frame-clip capt.	+0.05	+0.067 [+0.030, +0.108]
C2c video − frame-clip capt.	0.00	+0.013 [−0.030, +0.061]
C3, Sonnet captions (H reads)		
C3a Sonnet − self capt.	+0.09	+0.064 [+0.017, +0.111]
C3b Sonnet capt. − frames	+0.12	+0.094 [+0.044, +0.148]
C3c H on Sonnet capt. − S on frames	−0.07	−0.091 [−0.145, −0.040]
C3d Sonnet − Gem. frame-clip capt.	0.00	−0.017 [−0.071, +0.037]
C4, minimal pairs (pair accuracy, cl. CIs)		
C4a H: self capt. − frames	+0.06	+0.093 [+0.028, +0.161]
C4b H: Sonnet − self capt.	+0.09	+0.104 [+0.017, +0.190]
C4c H on Sonnet capt. − S on frames	−0.12	−0.176 [−0.276, −0.079]
C4d H: Gem. video capt. − frames	+0.18	+0.249 [+0.173, +0.319]
C4e S: own capt. − frames	−0.08	−0.176 [−0.260, −0.093]
C5, describe, then answer (H, cl. CIs)		
C5a describe − frames	+0.03	+0.071 [+0.029, +0.114]
C5b describe − self capt.	0.00	+0.040 [−0.011, +0.092]
C6, 448 px frames (H reads)		
C6a 448 − 224 px frames	+0.04	+0.037 [−0.010, +0.084]
C6b Sonnet capt. − 448 px frames	+0.07	+0.057 [+0.003, +0.111]
C6c Gem. video capt. − 448 px frames	+0.08	+0.088 [+0.037, +0.138]
C6d Gem. frame capt. − 448 px frames	+0.13	+0.141 [+0.088, +0.195]

Term	Pred.	Result [95% CI]
C7, audit: reader error / misstatement / omission		
H, self capt.	.20 / .30 / .50	.08 / .28 / .63
H, Gem. video capt.	.25 / .30 / .45	.10 / .21 / .69
S, Gem. video capt.	.15 / .35 / .50	.05 / .24 / .71
stacked: omission	$\geq$ .70	.93–1.00
reversed: misstatement	$\geq$ .50	.28–.45
C8, Sonnet on the question only		
C8a S − H, question only	+0.02	+0.003 [−0.061, +0.064]
C8b S: frames − question only	+0.37	+0.384 [+0.320, +0.451]
retention, S: Gem. video / own capt.	0.98 / 0.76	0.98 / 0.77
C9, Sonnet captions of 448 px frames		
C9a H: 448 − 224 px capt.	+0.03	+0.003 [−0.037, +0.047]
C9b H on 448 px capt. − S on frames	−0.06	−0.088 [−0.138, −0.037]
C9c S: own 448 px capt. − frames	−0.07	−0.067 [−0.114, −0.024]
C9d H: 448 px − Gem. frame capt.	−0.06	−0.081 [−0.131, −0.030]
C9e S: own capt., 448 − 224 px	+0.02	+0.020 [−0.024, +0.064]
C10, one caption per video		
C10a H: whole − window capt.	0.00	+0.013 [−0.027, +0.057]
C10b S: whole − window capt.	+0.01	+0.010 [−0.030, +0.051]
C10c H on whole − S on frames	−0.09	−0.077 [−0.128, −0.027]
C10d S: own whole − frames	−0.08	−0.077 [−0.125, −0.034]
C11, aspect-aware captions		
C11a H: aspect-aware − whole	+0.03	+0.027 [−0.013, +0.067]
C11b S: aspect-aware − whole	+0.03	+0.040 [+0.003, +0.081]
C11c H on aspect-aware − S on frames	−0.05	−0.051 [−0.104, +0.000]
C11d S: own aspect-aware − frames	−0.05	−0.037 [−0.081, +0.007]
C12, open-weights reader (Q reads)		
C12a own capt. − frames	−0.01	−0.121 [−0.172, −0.071]
C12b Sonnet − own capt.	+0.09	+0.125 [+0.074, +0.175]
C12c Haiku − own capt.	+0.05	+0.067 [+0.020, +0.114]
C12d Gem. frame-clip − own capt.	+0.08	+0.152 [+0.098, +0.205]
C12e Gem. frame − own capt.	+0.14	+0.178 [+0.125, +0.236]
C12f Gem. video capt. − frames	+0.12	+0.040 [−0.010, +0.091]
C12g Q − H, on Sonnet capt.	−0.05	−0.047 [−0.094, +0.000]
C12h Q − H, question only	0.00	−0.013 [−0.077, +0.051]

Table 7: Every term with a pre-specified prediction, in the order run. H = Haiku, S = Sonnet, Q = Qwen reading; capt. = captions. CIs are paired bootstrap over questions unless marked cl. (clip clusters).

2% stop rule): both windows of one video, blocked as prohibited content, and one window in each of two two-clip videos, where the window spans the cut and the frame captioner answered "ERROR". The 3 affected questions (all order) were dropped from every arm, leaving 297. Two of them are two-clip videos, so the exclusion slightly favours the frame captioner; at 3 of 300 questions it cannot move an estimate by more than 0.01.

- **Stop rule (C1).** The Claude quota rule stopped Sonnet's secondary arms (question only and 1 frame) after C1's main arms. Sonnet's question-only arm was run later as C8; Sonnet on 1 frame was never run.

- **Token checks (C2, C10).** C2's check expected $\approx$ 330 Gemini tokens per window and got 280 on split-screen videos; the video arm got the same counts for the same windows, so the rule was restated as "equal to the video arm's tokens" and held for 693 of 761 windows (the rest are short last windows, +2% in total). C10's check omitted a fixed cost of 3 tokens per image block; all three checked calls fit the corrected count exactly.

- **Predictions by type (C3).** Amendment 1 added by-type predictions for C3, after the exploratory by-type analysis of C1 and C2 and before any C3 call.

Deviations.

- Haiku did not keep to the 45-word limit: on the 761 confirmatory windows its captions have a median of 45 words and 47% are over it, against 16% for Sonnet, 10% for Qwen and none for Gemini. The most useful captions (Gemini's) are the shortest, so length does not explain the captioner effect.

- The development entries K1 and K2 were written before their runs but committed after them.

- The open reader (C12) differs from the Claude readers by design: greedy decoding without retry (an unparsed answer counts as wrong), Qwen's default system prompt, the content blocks joined into one message, no thinking, and no cost account.

- The rule for the development step K1 did not say what to do when its second stage was also ambiguous; it was, and the index direction was continued without claiming a tie.

Hand labels. the labels were blind to the judge, but made in a session where Claude (Opus) pointed out caption details on 6 items; κ is 0.81 with the first-instinct labels too.

D Tables by aspect and by video type

Table 8 gives the accuracy of every arm by video type and by aspect. Every stacked question is about speed, and every two-clip question is about order, so the two breakdowns overlap.

Table 9 gives the main differences by video type, with 95% CIs over clip clusters. They are descriptive: with 41–137 questions per type, only differences of about 0.1 or more can show.

E Additional results

Visual budget within Claude. Sonnet's captions of 448 px frames (up to 720 visual tokens per window, 3.6× as many) are no more useful to Haiku than its captions of the 224 px frames: +0.003 [−0.037, +0.047], against a predicted +0.03. With power ≈ 0.25 for +0.03, this is weak evidence against a small effect, but the CI rules out more than about +0.045. The two budget changes also differ in size (200 → 720 tokens here, ≈ 300 → 5,500 for Gemini).

Haiku on 448 px frames. At 448 px, Haiku's frames take 2,676 input tokens per question, 1.76× the 224 px arm, and gain +0.037 [−0.010, +0.084]. Captions at ≈ 1,280 input tokens still beat them: Gemini frame captions by +0.141 [+0.088, +0.195], Gemini video captions by +0.088 [+0.037, +0.138], and Sonnet captions by +0.057 [+0.003, +0.111]. The advantage sits on two-clip videos (+0.31 to +0.38), and for Gemini frame captions also on plain and reversed ones. On stacked videos, every caption arm is within ±0.07 of the 448 px frames.

Window length. We checked the per-window design against one Sonnet caption per video, from the same frames, with the length limit summed over the windows. Whole-video captions are no better: +0.013 [−0.027, +0.057] with Haiku reading, and +0.010 [−0.030, +0.051] with Sonnet (predicted +0.00 and +0.01). Splitting into 5 s windows thus costs at most ≈ 0.05–0.06, and helps by at most ≈ 0.03. On one-window videos, where the two captioning calls are identical, the difference is ≈ 0 for both readers (+0.02 and −0.02), as it should be. One by-type pattern was not predicted: Haiku gains +0.12 [+0.03, +0.23] on reversed videos from whole-video captions, while stacked videos lean the other way for both readers (−0.07 and −0.12; CIs include 0).

Resampling noise. On the 48 one-window videos, the captioning call is identical in both arms. None of the 48 caption pairs is identical, and the reader's answer changes on 10% (Haiku) to 17% (Sonnet) of those questions, as often as removing the split changes it on videos with two or more windows (17%). Per question, a caption is one sample.

Aspects (P1, null). The pre-registered aspect contrast, that captions lose direction and speed but keep the discrete aspects, did not pass: −0.101 [−0.231, +0.028] for Sonnet, half the predicted −0.20. Speed is the only aspect where captions lose consistently (−0.10 for Sonnet). Aspect nearly coincides with video type (Table 8).

Thinking (not predicted). At effort medium, the model decides per call whether to think, so thinking is observed, not set. On Gemini's captions, thinking marks wrong answers: accuracy is 0.84–0.90 on calls without thinking and 0.62–0.65 on calls with it. For Haiku on frames it does not (0.61 both ways). Sonnet thinks 3.3× less on captions than on frames.

Retention of every index (95% CIs over clip clusters). Haiku: self-captions 1.15 [0.91, 1.46], Sonnet captions 1.47 [1.18, 1.95], Sonnet 448 px 1.48 [1.20, 1.95], Sonnet whole-video 1.53 [1.22, 2.07], Gemini frame-clip 1.55 [1.27, 2.02], Gemini video 1.62 [1.33, 2.10], Gemini frame 1.88 [1.53, 2.51]. Every point estimate exceeds 1 because Haiku on frames is below what the captions hold. Sonnet: own captions 0.77 [0.64, 0.90], 448 px 0.82 [0.71, 0.93], whole-video 0.80 [0.67, 0.93], Gemini video 0.98 [0.85, 1.13]. Qwen: own captions 0.53 [0.34, 0.70], Sonnet captions 1.01 [0.85, 1.20], Gemini video 1.16 [0.98, 1.37].

The open reader in detail. Qwen reads Sonnet's captions 0.047 below Haiku ([−0.094, +0.000]; predicted −0.05): level on plain (+0.01) and reversed (+0.07) videos, and below on two-clip (−0.29 [−0.40, −0.17]) and stacked (−0.17 [−0.28, −0.05]) videos, where the answer must be combined across windows or copies. On the question alone it matches Haiku (−0.013 [−0.076, +0.047]). Its own captions lose most on reversed (0.26) and stacked (0.24) videos. The 49 unparsed

Reader, input	plain (137)	two-clip (45)	reversed (74)	stacked (41)	action (60)	attr. (60)	direction (60)	order (57)	speed (60)	all (297)
Haiku, question only	0.60	0.31	0.16	0.34	0.63	0.37	0.28	0.37	0.40	0.41
Haiku, 1 frame	0.77	0.62	0.27	0.49	0.88	0.55	0.32	0.65	0.52	0.58
Haiku, 5 frames	0.80	0.60	0.38	0.41	0.93	0.67	0.28	0.65	0.53	0.61
Haiku, 5 frames, 448 px	0.82	0.62	0.43	0.49	0.98	0.68	0.38	0.65	0.55	0.65
Haiku, describe, then answer	0.82	0.69	0.50	0.54	0.90	0.73	0.47	0.72	0.60	0.68
Haiku, self-captions	0.80	0.82	0.43	0.32	0.90	0.70	0.38	0.82	0.42	0.64
Haiku, Sonnet captions	0.85	0.93	0.45	0.44	0.97	0.72	0.42	0.91	0.53	0.71
Haiku, Sonnet captions, 448 px	0.88	0.87	0.46	0.41	0.95	0.77	0.43	0.84	0.57	0.71
Haiku, Sonnet whole-video	0.85	0.89	0.57	0.37	0.97	0.83	0.43	0.89	0.48	0.72
Haiku, Sonnet aspect-aware	0.88	0.96	0.58	0.39	0.95	0.88	0.43	0.95	0.53	0.75
Haiku, Gemini frame-clip	0.88	0.87	0.57	0.34	0.98	0.85	0.43	0.88	0.48	0.72
Haiku, Gemini frame	0.92	1.00	0.64	0.41	1.00	0.90	0.55	1.00	0.52	0.79
Haiku, Gemini video	0.86	0.93	0.53	0.49	0.95	0.82	0.43	0.93	0.57	0.74
Sonnet, question only	0.61	0.29	0.18	0.32	0.70	0.38	0.23	0.40	0.35	0.41
Sonnet, 5 frames	0.89	0.91	0.64	0.66	0.97	0.82	0.58	0.91	0.72	0.80
Sonnet, Sonnet captions	0.88	0.91	0.46	0.39	0.97	0.73	0.43	0.89	0.53	0.71
Sonnet, Sonnet captions, 448 px	0.88	0.96	0.49	0.41	0.95	0.77	0.48	0.95	0.52	0.73
Sonnet, Sonnet whole-video	0.90	0.93	0.51	0.27	0.98	0.82	0.45	0.91	0.45	0.72
Sonnet, Sonnet aspect-aware	0.92	0.96	0.55	0.39	1.00	0.87	0.45	0.95	0.55	0.76
Sonnet, Gemini video	0.93	0.98	0.57	0.54	1.00	0.82	0.55	0.98	0.62	0.79
Qwen, question only	0.50	0.42	0.23	0.32	0.58	0.38	0.28	0.44	0.30	0.40
Qwen, 5 frames	0.86	0.58	0.45	0.44	0.93	0.75	0.38	0.67	0.55	0.66
Qwen, Haiku captions	0.81	0.58	0.45	0.22	0.90	0.70	0.42	0.63	0.37	0.60
Qwen, Sonnet captions	0.86	0.64	0.51	0.27	0.98	0.78	0.43	0.70	0.40	0.66
Qwen, Gemini frame-clip	0.88	0.67	0.54	0.32	0.95	0.85	0.45	0.72	0.47	0.69
Qwen, Gemini frame	0.91	0.71	0.58	0.32	0.98	0.87	0.50	0.75	0.47	0.71
Qwen, Gemini video	0.89	0.76	0.50	0.34	0.97	0.80	0.47	0.77	0.48	0.70
Qwen, Qwen captions	0.75	0.60	0.26	0.24	0.90	0.53	0.28	0.58	0.38	0.54

Table 8: Accuracy by video type and by aspect, every arm (297 confirmatory questions; n in brackets).

answers are refusals, 42 of them on caption arms; without them, the captioner effect is +0.106, cl. [+0.052, +0.164], and the modality effect −0.103, cl. [−0.152, −0.055]. Its captions are shorter than Claude's (median 30 words; 10% over the 45-word limit).

Audit by video type. Two-clip failures are few (1–8 per arm) and mostly reader errors, where the captions state the order and the reader still answers wrongly. Plain failures are 0.60–0.80 omission; stacked failures 0.93–1.00. The hard items fall into four kinds: a static description that fits a wrong option; a near-synonym of an option; a 1 s last window that contradicts the long first one; and an answer that needs knowledge of the task (debris "tumbling upward" means "rebuilding" only to a reader who knows that clips may be reversed).

More on cost. Sonnet on its own captions repays after $Q_{\mathrm{BE}} = 8.9$ [7.8, 10.2], at −0.088. Haiku on Sonnet captions is +0.057 more accurate than Haiku on 448 px frames and cheaper per question, and repays after 57.5 [53.3, 62.1]. Latency does not favour captions: the median call on captions is 0.1–1.1 s slower than on frames with the same reader (CLI wall clock with start-up, not controlled for time of day). Thinking is 2–5% of reader tokens.

Longer videos. The clips average 2.6 windows, so the fixed reader prompt is a large share of each question's cost. We project the measured costs by Proposition 2: each arm's cost per question is its mean plus its input tokens per window (exact by construction: 200 for frames, 63–87 for captions) at its input price per extra window, and the index costs its mean per window times W. This assumes that output and thinking tokens do not grow with W, and that the reader reads every window. For one reader, the saving per question grows with length: Gemini video captions cost Haiku 0.82 of the frames' price per question at 2.6 windows, 0.59 at one minute (12 windows) and 0.38 at ten minutes (120), and Sonnet 0.70, 0.53 and 0.37. The break-even does not fall, because captioning grows with every window too: Haiku's Q_{BE} stays at 203–214, and Sonnet's rises from 5.9 to a limit of 10.7, since its fixed saving (less thinking on captions) counts for less on long videos. For the reader downgrade, the per-window indexes' Q_{BE} of 1.8–3.7 rises to 4.5–8.9 at one minute and to a limit of 7.2–14.5, while the cost per question falls from 1/25 to 1/50 of Sonnet on frames. The limit does not depend on the reader's fixed prompt, including the CLI's. A reader that retrieves a few windows instead of reading all saves less per question, so for it these Q_{BE} are lower bounds.

The reconstruction phase. Before this study, the project masked a gap of 1 s clips in 60 s videos and reconstructed it from the surrounding captions

Difference	plain (137)	two-clip (45)	reversed (74)	stacked (41)
P2 modality, H: self capt. − frames	−0.01 [−0.07, +0.06]	+0.22 [+0.10, +0.35]	+0.05 [−0.04, +0.15]	−0.10 [−0.26, +0.05]
P3 H: Gem. frame − self capt.	+0.12 [+0.06, +0.19]	+0.18 [+0.09, +0.28]	+0.20 [+0.09, +0.32]	+0.10 [+0.02, +0.19]
C2a H: Gem. frame-clip − self capt.	+0.08 [+0.01, +0.15]	+0.04 [−0.09, +0.17]	+0.14 [+0.04, +0.24]	+0.02 [−0.08, +0.14]
C3a H: Sonnet − self capt.	+0.06 [−0.01, +0.12]	+0.11 [−0.03, +0.24]	+0.01 [−0.08, +0.10]	+0.12 [−0.03, +0.28]
C3b H: Sonnet capt. − frames	+0.05 [+0.00, +0.11]	+0.33 [+0.20, +0.48]	+0.07 [−0.04, +0.18]	+0.02 [−0.16, +0.21]
C3c H on Sonnet capt. − S on frames	−0.04 [−0.10, +0.02]	+0.02 [−0.10, +0.13]	−0.19 [−0.32, −0.07]	−0.22 [−0.44, +0.00]
S1 S: Gem. video capt. − frames	+0.04 [−0.01, +0.09]	+0.07 [−0.02, +0.16]	−0.07 [−0.19, +0.05]	−0.12 [−0.31, +0.05]
S: own capt. − frames	−0.01 [−0.06, +0.03]	+0.00 [−0.06, +0.07]	−0.18 [−0.30, −0.05]	−0.27 [−0.47, −0.09]
S3 H: Gem. video capt. − frames	+0.06 [−0.01, +0.12]	+0.33 [+0.22, +0.47]	+0.15 [+0.04, +0.27]	+0.07 [−0.03, +0.17]
C5a H: describe − frames	+0.02 [−0.04, +0.08]	+0.09 [−0.06, +0.24]	+0.12 [+0.01, +0.23]	+0.12 [+0.00, +0.23]
C5b H: describe − self capt.	+0.03 [−0.04, +0.10]	−0.13 [−0.30, +0.02]	+0.07 [−0.04, +0.18]	+0.22 [+0.09, +0.37]
C10a H: whole − window capt.	+0.00 [−0.04, +0.04]	−0.04 [−0.14, +0.07]	+0.12 [+0.03, +0.23]	−0.07 [−0.21, +0.06]
C10b S: whole − window capt.	+0.02 [−0.01, +0.06]	+0.02 [−0.05, +0.10]	+0.05 [−0.06, +0.16]	−0.12 [−0.29, +0.05]
C11a H: aspect-aware − whole	+0.02 [−0.03, +0.07]	+0.07 [−0.03, +0.15]	+0.01 [−0.08, +0.11]	+0.02 [−0.08, +0.12]
C11b S: aspect-aware − whole	+0.02 [−0.02, +0.07]	+0.02 [−0.05, +0.09]	+0.04 [−0.05, +0.14]	+0.12 [+0.00, +0.26]
C12a Q: own capt. − frames	−0.11 [−0.18, −0.04]	+0.02 [−0.10, +0.13]	−0.19 [−0.31, −0.08]	−0.20 [−0.34, −0.05]
C12b Q: Sonnet − own capt.	+0.11 [+0.05, +0.18]	+0.04 [−0.09, +0.19]	+0.26 [+0.13, +0.39]	+0.02 [−0.10, +0.16]
C12g Q − H, on Sonnet capt.	+0.01 [−0.04, +0.05]	−0.29 [−0.40, −0.17]	+0.07 [−0.03, +0.17]	−0.17 [−0.28, −0.05]

Table 9: Differences in accuracy by video type (95% CIs over clip clusters). H = Haiku, S = Sonnet, Q = Qwen reading.

Reader, input	Acc.	In tok.	$/q	Index
H, 1 frame	0.582	1,189	1.46	—
H, 5 frames 448 px	0.650	2,676	3.39	—
H, describe, answer	0.684	1,579	4.15	—
H, Sonnet 448 px	0.710	1,279	1.80	11.67
H, Sonnet whole-video	0.721	1,194	1.56	4.92
H, Sonnet aspect-aware	0.747	1,213	1.62	5.27
S, Sonnet 448 px	0.731	1,281	31.03	11.67
S, Sonnet whole-video	0.721	1,196	28.49	4.92
S, Sonnet aspect-aware	0.761	1,215	28.97	5.27

Table 10: The variant arms, as in Table 3.

Index	Q_{BE}	Acc. difference
Gemini video	1.8 [1.7, 2.0]	−0.061 [−0.111, −0.010]
Gemini frame-clip	1.9 [1.8, 2.1]	−0.074 [−0.125, −0.024]
Sonnet captions	2.3 [2.2, 2.4]	−0.091 [−0.145, −0.040]
Sonnet, 448 px	3.0 [2.8, 3.1]	−0.088 [−0.138, −0.037]
Sonnet whole-video	1.2 [1.2, 1.3]	−0.077 [−0.128, −0.027]
Sonnet aspect-aware	1.3 [1.3, 1.4]	−0.051 [−0.104, +0.000]
Gemini frame	3.7 [3.5, 4.0]	−0.007 [−0.057, +0.044]

Table 11: Reader downgrade: Haiku on an index against Sonnet on 5 frames. Q_{BE} is the number of questions per video after which the index costs less in total (95% CI over questions).

or by interpolating frame embeddings. Continuity baselines were as strong as the models: an 8B LLM in-filling the masked captions lost to copying the nearest caption, and on forced-choice recognition (160 items), Haiku from captions was level with caption copy (51.2% vs. 45.6%), and frame copy (87.5%) was level with Opus (85.0%). Cosine similarity to the reference caption correlated with caption repetitiveness (Spearman $\rho = +0.61$), and per-second and order-free scoring gave opposite headlines. This is why the present study measures utility through a reader rather than similarity.

F Minimal-pair construction

For each confirmatory question, the sibling is the first video (sorted by ID) built from the same filmed clip that has a TempCompass question with the same aspect, stem and option set and a different correct option. Siblings are the plain and reversed versions of a clip, the other stacked versions (other speed pairs), and the other two-clip videos of the same two clips (other order or layout). Only siblings that Gemini had already captioned were used, which leaves out 3 reversal pairs. This gives 193 pairs: 107 reversal (66 with the reversed video in the confirmatory set, 41 with the plain one), 41 stacked and 45 two-clip, on 174 sibling videos (449 windows). Some siblings are development videos; each sibling item is still a new question–video combination. The sibling is read with the confirmatory question's wording and option order. Chance pair accuracy, both answers right by guessing, is 0.093.

Pair accuracies by group are in Table 4. By group (95% CIs over clip clusters): on stacked pairs, Haiku on Sonnet's captions trails Sonnet on frames by −0.34 [−0.60, −0.08], and Sonnet on its own captions trails its frames by −0.41 [−0.62, −0.23]; the same-answer rate is above Sonnet on frames' for Haiku on its own captions (+0.32 [+0.13, +0.49]), Haiku on Sonnet's captions (+0.32 [+0.07, +0.55]) and Sonnet on its own (+0.24 [+0.05, +0.43]), but not clearly for Haiku on Gemini's video captions (+0.22 [−0.02, +0.44]). On two-clip pairs, Haiku's own captions beat its frames by +0.36 [+0.16, +0.56]. On reversal pairs, Sonnet's captions beat Haiku's own by +0.06 [−0.01, +0.13], where a positive effect was predicted. Haiku on frames gives the same

Type (n)	Question only	Frames	Sonnet captions	Perception shortfall	Index loss
plain (137)	0.60	0.80	0.85	0.20 [0.13, 0.26]	−0.05 [−0.11, +0.00]
two-clip (45)	0.31	0.60	0.93	0.40 [0.30, 0.52]	−0.33 [−0.48, −0.20]
reversed (74)	0.16	0.38	0.45	0.62 [0.51, 0.73]	−0.07 [−0.18, +0.04]
stacked (41)	0.34	0.41	0.44	0.59 [0.45, 0.71]	−0.02 [−0.21, +0.16]
all (297)	0.41	0.61	0.71	0.39 [0.33, 0.44]	−0.09 [−0.15, −0.04]

Table 12: Table 6 for Haiku reading Sonnet's captions (95% CIs over clip clusters). Retention is 1.47 [1.18, 1.95] overall; by type it is not reported, because where Haiku's frames barely beat the question alone (stacked) its CI is unbounded.

letter on both videos of a pair 54% of the time, and on two-clip pairs its pair accuracy (0.18) is near chance.

G Release

We release the code, every caption, and every reader and judge output (prompt, raw answer, parsed answer and token counts per call), with the log of predictions written before each run. The repository's history is archived by Software Heritage (identifier withheld for review). An anonymized copy for review is at `https://anonymous.4open.science/r/dense_captions-26B/`. The videos and questions are TempCompass's (Liu et al., 2024), under CC BY-NC 4.0; we do not redistribute the videos or frames, and the captions, which describe them, are released under the same licence.